



Slow change

The big, spectacular dinosaurs may not have disappeared overnight. The world's climate could have cooled over millions of years, slowly killing them off. New plants grew in this colder climate. The warm jungles that covered most of the dinosaurs' world slowly turned into cooler forests.

What a hole

The asteroid impact formed a gigantic crater 115 miles (185 kilometers) wide in Yucatán, Central America. This photo shows a similar crater in Arizona that was made by a more recent asteroid impact.

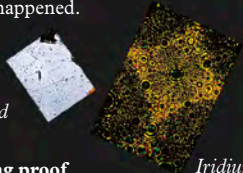


Wild guesses

Many theories try to explain the death of the dinosaurs. Some of the most unlikely include the idea that hungry mammals ate their eggs.



Or that dinosaurs were poisoned by new, nasty plants. But no single theory can explain what really happened.



Shocked quartz

Iridium

Finding proof

The asteroid crushed rock in the Earth's surface as it hit Yucatán. Shocked quartz has been found at the crater site. Iridium is a rare metal, found in asteroids. There are high levels of iridium in the rock that contains dinosaur fossils.

The survivors

Despite the disaster, a few animals survived. They included birds, mammals, reptiles, and amphibians that became the ancestors of animals that live around us today.



Bird



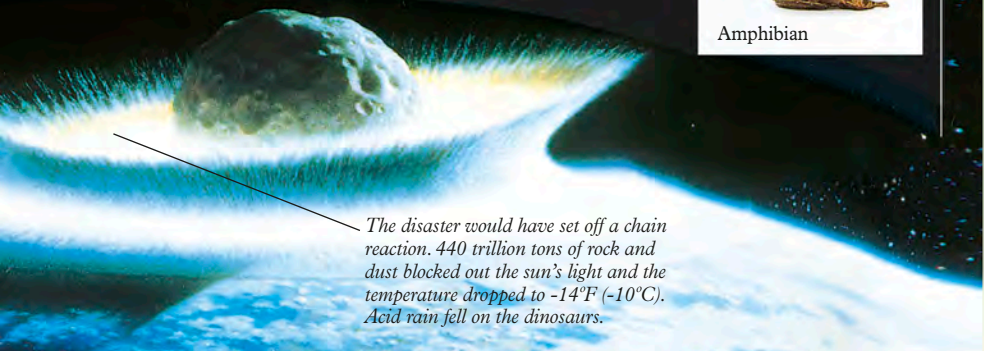
Mammal



Reptile



Amphibian



The disaster would have set off a chain reaction. 440 trillion tons of rock and dust blocked out the sun's light and the temperature dropped to -14°F (-10°C). Acid rain fell on the dinosaurs.